ARCHITECT GUIDE TO PERSONAL GROWTH

Logically assess life, develop abilities that enable progress, and optimize yourself

16Personalities

Table of Contents

Introduction 3
Fulfillment and Development 5
Self-Esteem 6
Balanced Self-Esteem 7
Unbalanced Self-Esteem 8
Rebalancing Self-Esteem 9
Self-Respect 11
Balanced Self-Respect 11
Unbalanced Self-Respect 12
Rebalancing Self-Respect 13
Self-Confidence 16
Balanced Self-Confidence 16
Unbalanced Self-Confidence 17
Rebalancing Self-Confidence 18
Self-Evolution 21
Balanced Self-Evolution. 21
Unbalanced Self-Evolution 22
Rebalancing Self-Evolution 23
Self-Responsibility 26
Balanced Self-Responsibility 26
Unbalanced Self-Responsibility 27
Rebalancing Self-Responsibility 28
Final Words 32
So... What's Next? 33

Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters to Architects

Personal growth isn't merely some theory to create a veneer of self-satisfaction – that would seem useless to Architects, who revere logical functionality. Personal growth is about judiciously assessing life, developing abilities that enable progress, and deliberately making useful changes. It's about striving to become the best possible version of oneself, including finding a heartfelt personal definition of "best." No set of ideals or goals fits all people, even of the same personality type, so it's essential that personal growth reflects an individual's true needs.

Want to understand the mechanics of what makes you tick? Learn about the traits that make up your personality type – and the theory behind them – here.

For Architects, growth is often about expanding beyond the familiar to explore alternative aspects of their potential. More than changing their essential personalities, personal growth means optimizing themselves to move forward. A big part of this growth is learning how to progress despite life's unexpected and unwelcome challenges. A healthy, balanced, and objective sense of self can help them overcome emotional troubles and practical roadblocks. It all starts with a willingness to look inward without shame, as well as an honesty in how they see the world.

Clinical, rationality-driven assessments are Architects' specialty. However, their keen perception isn't always matched with flexibility, as they strive to build unassailable opinions and stable practices through thoughtful deliberation. This way of living can grant them strength if

their decisions are wise but can also make it difficult or even dangerous for them to change, or even admit their own need for change. If they want to grow, these may be the greatest limitations they must master.

Developing Healthy Criteria

One major source of unhappiness in Architects' lives is the contrast between the internal ideals they hold so closely and the realities of the external world that conflict with their vision. They want to mold things as they see fit, and they become increasingly frustrated when they can't. Acceptance isn't easy for any of the Analyst types, especially when they think something is "right," "wrong," or "could be better" – and Architects often turn these observations into opportunities.

Trying to sculpt everything into conformity with their own conclusions can become a source of lifelong frustration for Architects. However, there's another way: personal growth isn't only about exercising their potential to the fullest, but about restructuring expectations to escape from the most extreme ideals. Nothing, and no one, is perfect all the time, and even the most perfectionist of Architects can learn to take some pressure off themselves and others by recognizing this fact.

The only true failure is giving up. When Architects learn to value themselves based on the merit of their efforts rather than by idealistic and static benchmarks, progress, success, and happiness can become enduring values. For them, personal growth isn't about measuring themselves against expectations – it's about maximizing their potential at any given moment.

Fulfillment and Development

Architects can work toward a more fulfilling life by focusing on five related, but distinct, motivational aspects of personal growth. The first three speak more to finding internal balance, and the latter two to engaging beneficial action. They are Introverted Judging types; therefore, much of what defines Architects' happiness is based on control and stability. However, their Intuitive trait also makes them hungry for understanding, creative expression, and future progress. For Architects, mastering a balance between exerting their highly specific vision and reshaping themselves when needed is critical to their personal growth – and happiness.

Real growth starts with an objective evaluation of their behavior to decide whether it's satisfying and effective. Then, growth involves creating options for improvement by reformulating actions and attitudes. Not all personal growth is the product of deliberate effort, though; sometimes it emerges naturally from ongoing maturity, is prompted by challenges and crises, or is learned from worthy and wise people. Architects can benefit from keeping their minds open to unexpected sources of knowledge because, as the saying goes, "You're either getting better, or you're getting worse. There's no staying the same."

Let's briefly define the five motivational aspects as they pertain to the Architect personality type.

Inner Satisfaction

- **Self-esteem** speaks to Architects' emotional harmony within themselves. They are not overtly emotive, but they are affected by their feelings, so learning to be happy with who they are is critical to a happy life.
- **Self-respect** is Architects' sense of their own worth. This personality type holds strong views, and when they put their ideas to work in the world around them, they find a balanced sense of pride.
- **Self-confidence** is the internal energy that helps Architects maintain momentum in the face of challenges. Fairly recognizing their own capabilities – and limits – gives them strength to move forward in life.

Active Progress

- **Self-evolution** describes the process of deliberate growth that Architects undertake to access their potential. Knowing when to rebuild themselves prevents them from stagnating and expands their abilities and wisdom.
- **Self-responsibility** is the ability to be conscious of their behavior and direction in life. Architects have little trouble deciding what they think is right, and they can solidify their responsible character by accepting accountability for their actions.

Architects' personal growth is aided greatly by their capacity for independent thought, as well as their innate talent for quickly deconstructing even the most intricate of designs. Although examining their own inherent biases and prejudices can prove challenging, this personality type rarely allows such complexity to dissuade them. Architects can be remarkably perceptive if they choose to analyze their own weaknesses. In doing so, they can exercise one of their greatest strengths: objectivity.

In each of the following sections, we will first examine how Architects use each of these five motivational aspects in balanced ways to lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives. Next, we will look at how Architects may stray from beneficial behaviors and discuss adverse effects they can experience as a result. Finally, we will consider ideas for rebalancing each motivational aspect to get things back on track.

Self-Esteem

Self-esteem is the quality of liking oneself, independent of things like societal measures, personal struggles, or self-perceived flaws. No one is perfect, but a positive self-image is a fertile foundation for growth. Without it, happiness becomes tremulously dependent on circumstance. Self-esteem comes from a stable internal state of self-love – something essential to strive for, yet not always easy to maintain.

Balanced Self-Esteem

Calculated Positivity

Architects often seem loosely attached to their emotions, but this perspective underrepresents their contemplative, logical way of viewing experiences and feeling inner positivity. They are rarely giddy, but when things go right they can feel a deep sense of self-satisfaction, and they feel great anticipation when approaching opportunities. Other types may try and prompt more expressiveness from them, but Architects can feel deep contentment even when their happiness seems reserved – their self-esteem keeps them in touch with a warm internal glow.

Architects don't feed off social connection like other personality types do, thus don't gravitate toward superficial excitement or widely share their feelings. This mindset may confuse those who value effusive style over substance, but Architects express their enthusiasm, kindness, and joy in thoughtful ways that they and their friends appreciate. For them, self-esteem doesn't come from pleasing the crowd, but from sincere living. When they express their feelings and thoughts honestly, they find satisfaction and happiness within themselves.

Inner Creativity

Known for their ability to deconstruct things, Architects also build complex ideas deep within their minds. Although they may often think in terms of technical mechanics, their aspirations can also be fantastic. Other people may appreciate them for what they do or how well they do it, but Architects draw self-esteem from learning to appreciate their internal inspiration. They want to be acknowledged, but such acclaim pales in comparison to the glee they feel when they have a grand idea brewing inside and let their imagination roam free; therein lies their unique capacity for self-fulfillment.

Creativity, even in its theoretical form, can be a source of profound joy for Architects if they allow themselves the freedom to enjoy it. Delving into their creative core without limiting themselves to the "realistic" is a great way to build self-esteem. Inspiration is precious to any creative type, and their bounty of imaginative ideas allows Architects to see a reflection of their own value. As they explore their internal world, they can feel pride and self-love based on merits that other people's opinions can't diminish.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Pointless Comparisons

One of the ways Architects commonly undermine their self-esteem is through comparison – their keen perception of the divide between "what is" and "what should be." Unfortunately, when they turn this scrutiny on themselves too sharply, it can create a sense of inadequacy. They may compare themselves against grand possibilities unhampered by realism. Self-esteem can't stand up to the infinite number of improvements Architects can imagine for themselves and the rest of the world – a fact that escapes this perfectionist personality type when their expectations fall out of balance.

This can be even more damaging if Architects compare themselves to other people. Comparing oneself to others is a common and often subconscious practice for many other types, and logic may mislead Architects into feeling bad about themselves simply because someone else exceeds them in one or more areas – a self-criticism with an unbalanced expectation of superiority at its core. They're proud of their abilities, and anything that usurps that pride can swing them much too far in the opposite direction, toward self-hatred.

Denying Their Humanity

Feelings of inadequacy and anger can be hard for Architects to process and release in healthy ways, causing them to stew in negativity for long periods. Consequently, they often try to gain control over their lives by repressing their emotions. Typically, this behavior comes about when they grow uncomfortable with their own humanity – for instance, if they view normal emotional expression as somehow revealing weakness. Such a perspective simply doesn't tell the whole story, and the struggle to deny feelings they think they shouldn't have can diminish their self-esteem. Because their resulting discomfort can manifest so strongly that other people notice, it often functions as a social barrier.

Architects striving for emotional control don't just create problems with perfectly natural negative feelings; they can also interfere with the propagation of the positive. Love, joy, desire, compassion, curiosity, and surprise can be as messy as they are wonderful – something Architects don't always find easy to integrate alongside their desire for

order. The magical, thrilling potential of life can seem dubious to them, and they may feel it necessary to assuage their hope and optimism along with their darker emotions. Unfortunately, denying their feelings is like settling for a life in the middle of the road, never seeing glorious vistas for fear of approaching the edge.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Constructive Regard

Comparative logic serves Architects well when it's connected to creativity rather than unrealistic expectations. They can boost their self-esteem by emphasizing how far they've come, rather than how far they've yet to go. All individuals are on highly personal journeys that have unique pitfalls and triumphs, and appreciating such a journey means focusing on *progress*, not *position*. Architects can discover a wellspring of self-esteem by recognizing their wonderful qualities and what they accomplish by using them.

Architects can also recognize that comparisons to other people are inherently flawed because no measurement suits everyone. It's easy to find others who are better at something – to expect otherwise is the height of arrogance. However, everyone has such diverse talents and abilities that whole, perfect comparisons are logically impossible and therefore a waste of time. Architects can solidify their self-esteem by improving themselves instead of worrying about how they size up to other people. Internal happiness isn't supposed to be relative, and the following exercise can help Architects realize that.

- Write down three praiseworthy, happy, personal choices, abilities, or pursuits.
- Think about how those things brought happiness and fulfillment. Note any associated positive feelings.
- Recall any personal benefits gained from those things, and note them as well.
- Acknowledge the fact that the good results came from within. Write "I did that" next to each positive gain listed.

- Commit to a cycle of self-fulfillment by engaging those happy things more deeply or creating new ones.

Architects can achieve a healthy foundation of self-esteem by making a conscious choice to view themselves positively. Backing this view with the evidence they require to truly believe something is as easy as looking at how their inner qualities have already brought them happiness. Comparisons to specifics bring transient satisfaction at best, while appreciating their inner core of ability can bring Architects sustainable appreciation for who they are.

Embracing Emotion

Architects often emphasize how things *should* be, but if that vision precludes honesty about their emotions, they can't be happy with themselves. Though it's okay to keep feelings private, acknowledging and understanding them internally helps these types achieve the stability they so prize. Consciously exploring emotions builds self-esteem because it grants control over their expression, rather than letting them manifest in disorderly ways that make people with the Architect personality type feel bad about themselves. These individuals take pride in proficiency, and emotional self-awareness exemplifies that proficiency.

When they practice accepting their feelings, not only are they happier with themselves, but they also naturally invite more joy into their lives. Repressed feelings can have a caustic effect that erodes self-esteem and breeds bitterness, interfering with social relations. When Architects choose to work forward from that repression, it not only brings the internal warmth of self-esteem, it also creates an appealing outward effect as well. Working through emotions is a lifelong process, but Architects' rational, methodical abilities serve them well. The following short exercise is one way they can start.

- When a feeling arises, observe it without judgement. After all, a feeling is a natural response of the brain, not a defining factor of one's being.
- Accept that emotions are an inevitable by-product of events, expected and not innately harmful if dealt with appropriately.

- Try and understand the source – what happened?
- Determine whether the root cause of negative feelings can be addressed. Take corrective action ASAP, then let it go instead of letting it fester.
- When positive feelings run high, let them flow outwardly. Any excuse for a laugh or a smile should be embraced, alone or with others.
- Discuss feelings with trusted friends or family. There's nothing better than verbalizing emotions to bring them into focus. Getting things out in the open can provide a clearer view of things.

Architects need not feel any shame for their level of emotional sensitivity, nor try and change who they are – if anything, self-esteem comes from appreciating themselves. For this controlled personality type, though, taking deliberate steps to get in touch with their emotional lives can be necessary to restore balance to how they feel about themselves.

Self-Respect

Self-respect differs from self-esteem in that it's less about emotional security with oneself and more about an objective appreciation for one's qualities and actions. Architects build this motivational facet by being honest with themselves, taking pride in what they do, and utilizing the talents that make them special.

Balanced Self-Respect

Guiding Principles

Architects are blessed with great imagination, but they also value organized, consistent systems. They can spend countless hours figuring out their ideal way to accomplish something, then translate that theory into a personal canon of life lessons. They create their principles through their search for function and by rational experimentation. Establishing their principles – and living by them – are among the core ways Architects build a sense of self-respect.

As Introverts, some Architects may be content to merely shape their own lives, but they tend to find even greater self-respect when they

can share their principles with the world. When they have an idea that works for them, they naturally think it can benefit others as well. Of course, Architects realize that not everyone has the same perspective, but their flexibility of mind allows them to tailor ideas to respect others' diverse needs. They find their greatest satisfaction when practicing their carefully crafted principles. Their sense of self-respect gets a boost when they put those principles to work for others.

Pride in Accomplishment

As rewarding as they can be, principles are only theoretical until they're put into action. Architects can build and maintain self-respect by proving what their principles can contribute to others. As Judging types, they seek to modify the world around them more than adapt to it; putting their theories to work is a critical step in this process. Instead of just thinking that something "should" be a certain way, Architects can challenge themselves to figure out a way to make it happen.

Not always quick to leap into changes, they nonetheless know when they must challenge the person in the mirror to "walk their talk." When Architects accomplish something, especially something new, they see the true strength of their abilities, and that's something they can respect deeply in themselves. Whether it's replacing a faucet or writing a novel, they appreciate their worth when they act, then incorporate that value into their inner view.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

Superiority Complex

Self-respect gives internal strength, but when they feel the world is challenging their ideas, Architects may find themselves internally divided. For people who pride themselves on their mental ability, they may find it all too easy to dismiss external criticisms or contradictions. This can be a trap, one that Architects fall into easily: When their self-respect manifests as intellectual smugness, their rejection of other people's ideas and principles deprives Architects of opportunities to learn. Lording their wisdom over others may feel like an elevated position, but engaging with, and contributing to, the world around them brings far more value.

Architects may also be tempted to belittle the contributions and ideas of others, devaluing what they see as flawed efforts, to make themselves feel better about their level of ability. When they doubt themselves, they may seek an easy intellectual victory instead of addressing the root cause of any insecurity – making a quick patch, one likely to fail again, instead of a thorough repair. Arguments can be factually correct and weak at the same time; if self-respect is like a strong spine, arrogance is more like a flimsy crutch.

Passive Punditry

Another Architect tendency is to search for self-respect through intangible intellectual victories rather than engaging in material challenges. When Architects turn their wit and intellectual prowess primarily to theory, commentary, and opinion, they tend to impress, and that inflates their sense of themselves. However, this focus on philosophical output may cause them to miss opportunities to flex their mental muscle through learning, creating, and solving real problems. No matter how insightful, clever, or correct, Architects who are "all talk" build little – other than the laurels on which they rest.

Likewise, the self-respect built through commentary without participation is thin – not necessarily false or undeserved, but limited nonetheless. Ideas are wonderful because they're the seeds of creative acts, but without nurturing, ideas can't bloom into their full potential, and neither can the people who conceive them. Brilliant imagination and perceptions are things to be proud of, but Architects may forego a lot of respectable accomplishments if they don't take additional steps to turn brilliance into something functional.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Cooperative Brilliance

Architects can appreciate the ideas and efforts of others without diminishing their sense of self-respect. One of the most crucial elements in any scientific endeavor is the notion of peer review – the idea that where an individual might err due to inherent bias or simple accident, a group of well-informed individuals can compensate for such

errors. Architects can apply this concept to their thoughts and opinions, maintaining their proud intellectuality while seeking ways to refine and prove their ideas among others, not against them.

Instead of defending their self-respect against conflicting views or information, Architects can evaluate and absorb worthy input to reinforce the strength of their position. If not useful, they can simply recognize that different views, lifestyles, and choices need not threaten them. In fact, self-respect demands that they ensure their notions are correct, so testing them against alternative views can bring wisdom. By remaining open-minded and allowing for the possibility of their own shortcomings, Architects aren't limiting themselves, but instead giving themselves the opportunity to improve.

Here are some tips Architects can use to identify these kinds of opportunities.

- When something challenges existing conclusions:
  - Don't dismiss it right away, even if it seems foolish.
  - Take it apart mentally to see how it might work.
  - Think about how it may be valid for others.
  - If useless, let it go. Something that's wrong need not affect you, nor be attacked – to each their own.

For Architects, struggling to be "right" is a noble cause when it's about improving themselves, but the wise recognition that others are on that same path means allowing each person to advance in their own way. Architects can build self-respect by reaching their own high bar, not by setting high bars for others.

Engaging a Project

Architects can choose to pursue their inspirations with more than just words; if they're builders (as their name implies), then they can build something respectable. Such projects demand both awareness and engagement, and Architects may find their respect for themselves deepening as they express themselves in deed as well as thought. The self-respect earned through an endeavor is dependent not on its

success or failure but on their fidelity to the project, so willing effort is more than a great start – it's a worthy end unto itself.

Projects can be short- or long-term, but they must capture Architects' imagination, compelling them to use their minds toward a chosen goal. When setbacks occur, Architects can forgive themselves for the fact that they can't control external factors and take on the challenge of compensating for them with a can-do attitude. They can also work on their own limits – the most respectable project of all. Architects can demonstrate their worth to themselves by the strength of their efforts. All they need is the self-respect to fail without shame and try again.

To engage their creative abilities, they might try the following:

- Pick an inspiring personal interest, something where strong ideas and imagination can be translated into external action – anything from taking a class in a subject of interest to creating a home garden.
- Set a time to start this pursuit – today, if possible.
- Set a reasonable goal – realistically define what success looks like.
- Set a schedule of when to work on the project and stick to it.
- Try to make every investment of effort as possible. Remember, the end goal is only half the point. This is also a chance to respect the efforts made, and every completed step is its own success.
- When finished, pick another project and repeat the exercise, always with personal fulfillment and creativity in mind.

Architects may have respectable minds, but their traits make them suited to more than just dissertation. Their self-respect is greatest when they use their minds to effect change. A solid answer to the question "What did I accomplish today?" is a powerful self-affirmation.

Self-Confidence

Self-confidence propels Architects to explore their full potential, share their ideas, and accomplish their goals in life. Self-confidence can be affected by external feedback, but it starts from within, building on the foundation of self-esteem and self-respect by relating those inner strengths to the exterior world. Everyone wants to feel capable, and for Architects, self-confidence is important because it opens the door to action.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Sincere Selves

Architects care little for small talk and casual pleasantries, seeing such social conventions as noise that can obscure the signal of far more pertinent information. Although their direct manner might not win them any popularity contests, it can be refreshing compared to a gentle but more evasive style, and much of their self-confidence stems from this intention toward substance. Though they might not be habitual people-pleasers, Architects can be delightfully fascinating, and they tend to be interested in meeting kindred spirits in their own reserved way.

Even though Architects may appear stilted and unnatural when out of their comfort zone or in inane conversations, they come alive and are excited to share what they think when talk turns to a compelling topic. Though their cutting insights at times verge on tactless, they're often so profound that others brave the sharp edges to join the conversation. Architects find such mutually inspired give-and-take exhilarating. Not typically sociable, Architects may be near-strangers to the pleasant stimulation of social inclusion, so when they find it through an intellectual path, it boosts their self-confidence.

Willful Insistence

Self-confidence isn't just about relating to others. For Architects, it's very much about the will to persevere in the face of unexpected challenges and learn from occasional mistakes. When they set their sights on a goal, their stubbornness can become an asset, and they do whatever it takes to be successful. Those who believe in their own abilities can maintain their self-confidence despite knowing they can't predict and

control everything – they simply take a deep breath, figure things out, and determinedly move forward.

The wisest Architects don't necessarily regard setbacks with excessive frustration, but rather as an intrusion of unsolicited but potentially valuable, even exciting knowledge. Anything broken can be rebuilt, and examining how breaks happen is a critical step in design evolution toward a more durable result. Architects have an uncanny ability to understand problems and imagine solutions, and self-confidence helps them feel able to make just about anything better, including their own futures.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

A Prickly Attitude

Appearances matter more than Architects often realize. They may believe that being direct is a compliment to the intelligence of other people, and that directness equates self-confidence. Architects become unbalanced when they carry their intellectual vigor too far, driving away or offending those whom they think have nothing of value to contribute. They might assume that worthy people are strong enough to overlook brusqueness, especially if it's just due to excitement. They may simply wave away any sense of responsibility for hurting people's feelings.

Intellectual aggression can underlie insecurity more than self-confidence and is often just an understandable side effect of Architects' tendency toward social awkwardness. Architects rarely build robust, lasting self-confidence from such attitudes, however. If anything, the apparent strength of their minds – and the true self-confidence they derive from their wit – is diminished by bluster. When they close themselves to outside ideas, they miss out on opportunities to exercise their intellect through fair exchange, which isolates them instead of letting them shine confidently.

The Stress of Failure

To put it simply, Architects are demanding. They have imaginative yet exacting expectations that are hard to meet, and their incisive

nature sometimes turns inward. Self-confidence means making room for ambitious hopes, but when failure dashes their dreams, they may lose momentum. This is especially common when benchmarks such as academic accomplishments, professional status, or personal relationships are at stake. When Architects put too much pressure on themselves, the specter of failure can bleed the joyful energy from what should be exciting pursuits.

Anticipating failure to try and prevent it can be a draining proposition. Failures are inevitable and prevalent in life, and they pose a challenge for a personality type whose ethos is to figure out the best way to do things. When Architects tie their own sense of worth to their goals, anything less than unmitigated success can damage their self-confidence, even though mistakes are natural parts of the learning process. Guilt and blame are common traps Architects fall into when they feel that they've failed, and they may talk themselves out of further efforts, believing they'll simply fail again.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Sharing Conversation

Though sharp-tongued, Architects can rebalance their presentation by understanding that the difference between a wise luminary and a callous blowhard is the way their words make other people feel. Their words can carry weight, and how they use them is critical. Intelligence isn't always about winning arguments with verbal prowess; it's about embracing the mutual elevation that communicating knowledge brings. Architects create a balanced sense of self-confidence when they foster brilliant conversations enjoyed by all, rather than trying to show off.

Silence also carries much weight, especially when Architects have established their wit. When they impress with their intellect, people respect them. Nothing makes them feel more self-confident than being an authority on a subject, but often, the best way to use such confidence is to let others express themselves and feel respected. Those who are willing to share conversation – including stepping down from the lectern now and then to listen and ask their own questions – are appreciated.

Here are some tips Architects can use to help build balanced conversations:

- Enter or start conversations with gentle inquiry rather than force.
- Speak thoughts fully, but don't hold the floor too long.
- Truly listen to what others have to say in response.
- Ask questions and show interest in people's thoughts.
- If asked questions, try to give useful, considerate answers. Share knowledge, don't just display it.
- Allow others their own perspective, even if it's disagreeable. Not every argument needs to occur.
- If challenged, remain calm, be polite, and stick to the facts.
- Feel free to politely exit conversations that become repetitive or negative.
- End exchanges with thoughtful positivity – "That's interesting, I'll have to think about that!"

Rebalancing a sharp manner doesn't require insincerity or effusive warmth on the part of Architects, but rather fair give-and-take when demonstrating knowledge and ability. Self-confidence need not be adversarial, and the positive responses gained from constructive exchanges only add to confidence.

Willingness to Fail

Failure is hard for Architects because they tend to put a lot of imagination and planning into things. However, as trite as it sounds, every failure is an opportunity. More to the point, perfection is a logical impossibility, and accepting the inevitability of occasional failure releases them from guilt. Instead of pinning their self-confidence on binary measurements of success (and suffering through all the attendant stress that such narrow views bring), Architects can accept their ongoing improvement.

Another way to approach failure is to see it as stepping on a different forward path rather than reversing direction. To restore balanced self-confidence, Architects can recover some value from disappointing

experiences by mining them for every possible grain of knowledge. They can ask, "What can I learn from this?" and scrutinize the situation with all their intellectual might to extract useful insights.

Self-confidence comes from making progress, but without a willingness to fail – and learn from failure – progress is timid and slow at best. Those who define themselves only by their successes have many opportunities to feel terrible, but those who take a balanced approach by forging setbacks into something useful continually affirm their ability to progress – and the self-confidence that stems from such ability. One bold way to practice handling failure is to deliberately engage it with low stakes. To try this, Architects can consider the following exercise:

- Pick a completely unfamiliar skilled activity – a painting night, tennis lesson, dance class, or public karaoke, for example. Find something so outside existing skillsets that proficiency is *very* unlikely.
- Consider inviting others. Handling failure in front of peers is a great skill to develop.
- Relax the mind and stay in the moment.
- Engage in the activity.
- While doing it, deliberately set these mental goals for success:
    - Sincere effort
    - Lightheartedness
    - Expanding physical or emotional limits
- During the activity, self-observe stress levels. Are ego or unrealistic expectations of success interfering with learning, progress, and enjoyment? Don't let them.
- Laugh away any embarrassment.
- Learn from the experience instead of feeling bad about it.

When Architects learn to handle failure and try again, they create a sense of self-confidence that mitigates missteps. Letting go of frustration, anger, and sadness to put that energy into reaching a goal is a powerful skill that gets easier the more it's practiced.

Self-Evolution

Change can be hard, and the need for it isn't always apparent to Architects who have carefully built a seemingly satisfying and secure life, but that shouldn't preclude their pursuing further progress. Self-evolution is the idea that they can turn their love of understanding and optimization to the infinite complexity of who they are and constantly look for ways to improve.

It's very important to realize that self-evolution isn't necessarily about making specific measures, but rather about creating personal fulfillment and extracting whatever they desire from life. This may include academic or financial aspirations or something as soul-satisfying as mastering brush and canvas. It may also mean developing their emotional intelligence to better understand themselves and others. The point of self-evolution isn't to be on an austere, obligatory march toward a goal, but to continuously develop personal potential to its fruition.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Dynamic Combination

Architects tend to be independent thinkers, capable of conceiving grand ideas with the precise clarity of a blueprint. They rarely need outside influence to be successful, only the time and skills necessary to methodically complete their plans. They may not often seek the social or intellectual embrace of others, but they respect those who add to their knowledge. The drive to cultivate every aspect of their lives keeps Architects open to advantageous information, and they welcome worthy people and their ideas.

For those intent on self-evolution, this willingness to include others doesn't stop with people who mimic their own thinking – that would merely be confirmation of what they already know. The people who offer Architects the most benefit are often those who meet their standards of capability and reason yet challenge them with new or unfamiliar thoughts that expand their understanding. Such individuals validate that they are open to diverse truths by helping Architects see what they might miss on their own – a powerful combination greater than the sum of its parts.

Judicious Transformation

Self-evolution is more than merely considering new perspectives – Architects understand that information and wisdom are only as good as how they're applied, and they love finding mechanisms that can improve their lives. Architects deeply value consistency, but they also want to advance their methods and views. This ongoing process often leads them to difficult moments of decision. Letting go of a habit can almost feel like admitting a mistake, but they understand it is a necessary step to creating something better.

For a stability-minded Judging type, adaptation and change can be daunting, but Architects' fertile imaginations keep the door propped open for new thinking. Even more importantly, valuing rational logic requires them to recognize their own mistaken perceptions and correct them – the only thing they dislike more than being wrong is ongoing wrongness. Recognizing opportunities to evolve doesn't always mean a leap of faith, however, and Architects are careful in their evaluations, always assessing potential benefits. When they change their minds about anything, they demand – and rightfully so – that such changes make sense.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

My Way or the Highway

Architects' mental independence can make them unparalleled self-starters, but their disdain for what they regard as arbitrary rules and unmerited authority can turn cooperative efforts into trials – their respect is often grudging. Their default position is to trust their own judgement more than others; when unbalanced, such self-reliance can make them antisocial. It's easy for them to get so caught up in their own perceptions that they lose touch with the value of what others can teach them.

Unfortunately, Architects' egos tend to grow along with their minds. If they choose to ignore the balancing virtues of other people's ideas and even their very company, they can stagnate in isolation. Instead of inclusive mental evolution expanding their capabilities, intellectual self-referencing can create vulnerabilities. Architects may feel accomplished,

only to find that they've been developing their minds and skills in an echo chamber, and that when it comes to dealing with other people and the broader world, their perceptions differ from reality.

Stuck on Same

Even Architects' keen analytical minds are put to the test when it comes to an objective review of their own deeply held conclusions. Architects aren't immune to the blinding effects of pride, and the more sincerely they try to optimize their views and actions, the more they may encase themselves in rigid routine. Even their most advanced views can be limiting if they become convinced they've achieved their personal pinnacle, and their search for an evolving ideal may sadly be replaced with reliance on a static model.

Resistance to change can also breed defensiveness, as Architects may confuse inflexible thinking with the righteous buttressing of truth when they work to defend even outmoded convictions. People with this personality type can be passionate and shrewd in their search for knowledge, but if they cling too tightly to established concepts (something they may rail against in others), they almost certainly limit their knowledge – and their personal growth. Change is inevitable, and fighting it can consume energy they could otherwise spend on advancing instead of standing still.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Cooperative Evolution

A single fish in a pond is automatically the biggest fish in the pond, but Architects can only evolve so far in solitude. Although this individualistic personality type may not thrive on warm social cohesion, opening themselves to the input of others can strengthen their thinking, either by solidifying or restructuring it. Rational self-interest demands they pursue the best option, and the first step is willing integration. Other people and their differences don't necessarily threaten their established order, and new views can enhance Architects' treasured conclusions if they prove worthy.

The second step is testing that proof – Architects needn't resort to assumption or belief to embrace what others have to offer. When they fairly evaluate the contributions and thoughts of other people, they can honor their own perspective while also being inclusive. They may find kernels of wisdom that advance their own thinking or simply come to understand others' unique perspectives better. Either result can break down social and intellectual barriers that inhibit creativity and cooperation.

These simple steps can help prevent Architects from dismissing someone else's idea:

- Put contentious ideas to a test before dismissing them. Thinking something through isn't enough; empirical evidence helps to either refute an idea or understand its benefits.
- Ask the person for as much detail as possible.
- Ask for a demonstration of how they make it work in their life.
- Apply their approach sincerely to test its usefulness. Keep in mind that it may end up being a worthy, useful idea or perspective, so real effort here is both fair and wisely self-serving.
- Give it more than one chance, and try it under different circumstances.
- Look for ways to hybridize and adapt others' ideas to make them personally suitable – it's not a contest, it's about searching for improvement.

When Architects decide to embrace – or at least evaluate – a foreign view or practice, it doesn't diminish their own preferred way of doing things. On the contrary, it's about using honest experimentation to decide for themselves the best way.

Making Room for Change

Architects can take a lesson from the laws of physics: Absolute rigidity produces lack of movement and eventual fragility when enough force is applied. Those who don't wish to be frozen in place or broken must develop some pliancy, and with Architects' ability to examine and

explore reality, deftly embracing change is within reach. Their ability to assess probabilities helps ease them into changing their minds – even if they can't see what might occur, they can remain open to making the best decisions as new options present themselves.

A willingness to evolve their conclusions is a huge asset to Architects and can relieve a lot of stress. Sticking to assumptions and proven practices may seem like a source of stability, but it also can cause missed opportunities and friction. Instead of insisting only on what they've decided, they can be ready to change when needed, keeping their established understanding as a sturdy foundation but building on it from any source they can. A measure of openness combined with their sense of commitment allows true wisdom to blossom.

Architects can practice positive change voluntarily with this exercise:

- Pick one aspect of the self, mind, or life in general that could change for the better. It can be anything that creates personal satisfaction, even if it isn't easy or completely enjoyable, but it should focus on improving an internal attitude or behavior (for example, being more patient, friendly to strangers, or emotionally open).
- Decide to practice this change at least once per day.
- Pick or design an opportunity each day to practice the new attitude. In the above examples, the first two might both be served by deliberately getting into a long coffee line and chatting cheerfully while waiting, and the latter could be served by taking that coffee to a friend and having a deep conversation.
- Feel free to include anyone who can help things proceed. Welcoming help from others is a great way to support personal change.
- While engaged, evaluate the benefits gained from the efforts, and use them to drive commitment to further changes.
- Change it up after a week or two. Pick another thing to change and start the process over again – always be building or advancing at least one quality of the self.

Architects are well suited to identifying areas for change in their own lives and to following through once they decide to commit to them –

it's that initial decision that can require some serious effort. A sense of obligation to themselves can help keep Architects focused on self-evolution, knowing that, ultimately, they'll reap rewards far greater than the comfort of resting on their laurels.

Self-Responsibility

This personal growth facet is about Architects' awareness and what they value. People with this personality type are capable of great dedication to whatever they hold dear, whether it's caring for a family, excelling at a job, or breathing life into a creative project. However, they don't always consider their relationships to the world and people around them as high priorities. Consciously expanding such objectives is key to personal growth, and self-responsibility helps Architects create both accountability and control in their lives.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Creating Positive Results

Architects have a gift for dissecting concepts and events, looking both backward and forward in time to see causes and probabilities surrounding almost anything. Blending this ability with self-responsibility gives them influence over such events by choosing how they react to them. Architects crave control, but because they aren't the only actors in the game of life, that's not always possible. They create balance when they use their abilities to overcome whatever happens instead of railing against unwelcome fate.

This is more of an *attitude* of action rather than a specific course of action. For Architects, self-responsibility means using whatever knowledge and power they have to the greatest possible benefit. True greatness – and personal growth – is less a measure of ability itself, and more so of how that ability is used. When Architects claim accountability for their lives, they empower themselves, and every adversity becomes an opportunity to learn, refocus, and create a better future.

Being Accepting

As Architects take responsibility for meaningfully crafting their paths,

they may sometimes come up against seemingly immovable and upsetting things or people. Tolerance isn't always easy for a personality type that so clearly envisions their ideal world, yet Architects often find it to be the most balanced and functional solution available. When other people, events, or facts of life seem outrageous to them, they balance their judgements by recognizing that it's not their responsibility to "fix" everything – sometimes it's not even an option. Knowing when to accept that which they cannot or need not change can save them much stress.

Though Architects may have to work harder than most to overcome judgement and release themselves from the pressure of creating perfection, making such ongoing efforts can lead them toward balanced self-responsibility. They find balance by seeing the practical value of moving forward instead of wasting time and energy on negativity – they have better uses for their heads than beating them against a wall. When they practice balanced acceptance of circumstances, they can discover that a calmer state of mind often brings solutions. When they do this with other people, they can find unexpected cooperation that enhances their lives.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Destructive Blame

Architects tend to see everything as a system, and they are often able to see how things work in complex detail. This can be a virtue when they're feeling creative, but when they experience misfortune, their analytical tendencies can lead to blame, tearing apart anything that offends them. It's all too easy for such perceptive types to ladle out criticism when it's so clear how things went wrong and how they should be, but this only serves to create frustration, no matter how legitimate the complaint.

This is one of the most common issues for Architects to master. Intent on their own views, their imagination and determination combine into a firm vision. Contradictions to that ideal can seem to threaten their goals and their core values, provoking outrage. Unfortunately, they tend to express this anger toward the nearest perceived inadequacy,

whether a mechanism, method, or mankind. When Architects blame, they consume energy that could otherwise be used to move forward, but their traits make it very difficult for them to let go, especially if they feel that they have facts on their side.

Intolerance

It's understandable for Architects to be frustrated – with their keen perceptions, they see the myriad problems inherent to everyday reality. However, when they harshly judge everything they see as "broken," or force change where it's not wanted, this unbalanced approach can have unhealthy consequences. It's simply unrealistic to attempt to make everything the way they think it should be, and when such overreaching efforts fail, it can lead to bitterness. When Architects let their righteous indignation get out of hand, they may exhaust themselves with the stress of constant intolerance.

Such an unbalanced attitude not only threatens Architects' own happiness and health but also can be hurtful to others, damaging personal and professional relationships. Self-responsibility certainly includes taking progressive or curative action, but when they feel they have the obligation – or right – to judge and control everything, Architects find themselves at odds with people in their lives and the world around them.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Constructive Choices

Life presents nearly infinite opportunities for criticism – the world is full of flaws and flawed people. However, blame is a wasteful way for these capable and creative people to use their energy. Instead, as their name implies, Architects can take responsibility for designing and building better things. There's great value is rooting out the cause of any problem, and once it's found, they can turn their frustration into constructive action instead of uselessly holding onto disdain or anger. Embracing self-responsibility is a gesture of power because it claims an ability to effect change.

Self-responsibility also means learning from problems with an eye toward preventing them in the future. Architects might accurately fault external causes for certain issues, but such events can also be great teachers if they replace abject blame with inquisitive rationality. Also important is the question of personal responsibility – Architects can humble themselves to look honestly at whether or how they've participated in creating a problem. It often takes two to tango. Hiding from their own culpability isn't only a denial of responsibility, but also a denial of their freedom to choose a better destiny.

When something goes wrong in life, Architects can use the following steps to help turn their energy toward progress instead of blame:

- What happened? Before assigning blame, seek answers with a cool, analytical mindset. Truth may come to light that provides a useful perspective.
    - Go over the chain of events to uncover the details of what happened. Ask questions of others if needed.
    - If the root problem can be identified, see if it can be fixed. This is also a great time to seek the counsel of trusted and respected friends and family.
    - Map things out on paper, if needed, using cause-and-effect logic.
- Embrace the power of forgiveness. Inanimate objects can't give apologies, and people can't undo history. Recognize the beneficial effect of forgiveness for the person who gives it. Stress and anger not only make life miserable, they also do real physical and mental harm, so it makes logical sense to let them go.
- Move forward. Feelings of blame don't always go away quickly; staying focused on progressive action is helpful.
- Elevate others. Instead of pointing out how people are wrong, respectfully offer them mentorship – and be graceful if they decline.

The above are rational steps, but sometimes frustration and desire to blame can be raw. When this occurs, consider this classic but always helpful tool that any type can use to release emotion:

- Let it all out in writing. Writing a letter that's never meant to be read can also be used to rebalance blame. Write an unrestrained rant

to the source of the problem and then burn it – repeat as much as desired. Let the act of composing and expressing thoughts and feelings create a sense of personal validation, but then let them go and move on to happiness and progress.

Architects can create balanced self-responsibility by dedicating themselves to improving things instead of blaming themselves, others, or circumstances for their problems. Releasing blame can be a rational investment in personal health.

Picking the Right Battles

Tolerance and acceptance can seem like flimsy concepts to Architects confronted by something or someone they think is functionally unacceptable, personally offensive, or provably wrong. However, because omnipotence is off the table, these positive concepts are great options. When Architects practice the art of tolerance, they rebalance a tendency to judge that drains them and pushes others away.

Tolerance is sometimes seemingly at odds with logic (truly bad things and people do exist), so this practice is more about personal discipline and emotional self-control – skills that Architects prize. Calm reason helps them embrace acceptance; when something is beyond their power to change, it logically makes little sense to spend energy on it. It's an excellent opportunity to use a logical mindset to decide on a more efficient use of personal resources.

Architects can prioritize their focus where it'll do them the most good. Many things this imaginative personality type may rail against are conceptual or distant, with little direct bearing on their own lives. It's great to maintain lofty principles, but constantly doing intellectual battle in the clouds may accomplish little to bring about happiness. Leaving airy arguments to come back down to Earth is a magnificent demonstration of self-responsibility.

Here's an exercise Architects can use to practice tolerance (it requires a little planning in advance):

- Enter a social situation antithetical to personal opinions (a progressive atheist could sit in the back of an orthodox religious service, for example.)

- Quietly listen and absorb.
- Allow internal judgement (intolerance), but simply observe it instead of delving into it.
- If emotions like anger or frustration come up, feel them for five seconds, then refocus on something else. Repeat as needed. It's important to respect and allow emotions to be felt, even while you are rebalancing them.
- Leave the situation, and upon exit, turn around and say, "That was then and there."
- Put the offensive experience aside – don't contemplate or discuss it, just file it away.
- Go to a close friend (or group) and have a fun interaction – anything enjoyable and stress-free.
- Focus fully on the good interactions and feelings.
- Briefly detach from and observe the happy moment, thinking, "This is what I want in my life."
- In the most private and peaceful space readily available, compare the two events side by side for a few minutes. Which one fosters a healthy, happy life? Which one is harmfully stressful? Is that one necessary? What does it accomplish, realistically?
- Consider that the objectionable thing will always be there, but the choice is there not to visit it, literally *or* metaphorically.
- Take this idea into everyday life – decide what to "visit" and where it's beneficial to place focus and energy.

There's no magic bullet with which Architects can fight their own sense of outrage, especially when they perceive genuinely odious things. However, being right isn't always enough to make life happy. Sometimes victory lies in knowing which battles can't be won, understanding which will result in a pyrrhic victory (won at too great a cost to have been worthwhile), or choosing to avoid a life of battle in the first place.

Final Words

Architects spend their lifetimes trying to understand things, and place great value on finding advanced perspectives and practices to help them lead better lives. Turning their mental faculties inward to see how they might challenge and improve themselves is a natural extension of this, as is expressing that inner development in positive ways. Personal growth is different for everyone, and individual Architects may find some things presented here ringing true more than others, but they can keep as shrewd an eye on themselves as they do on everything else.

It's likely that these types find some of their greatest challenges within, especially being able to find a sense of direction for their personal growth that creates happiness. Whether it's working on tolerance, social openness, emotional intelligence, or simply patience with a world that can seem to drag them down, Architects can find inspiration and growth every day if they choose. For these types, the tools to understand and accomplish this are within them, but learning new ways to act on their gifts may require occasionally uncomfortable leaps – not necessarily of faith, but of open-minded experimentation.

Few other types equal Architects' ability to design systems and processes, and learning to view themselves as a flexible, constantly improving component in the plan can unlock their potential in life. When they build self-esteem and self-respect, they can become comfortable enough with themselves to see their own flaws without guilt or shame, and find the self-confidence to insist on meeting their own goals. When these types willingly engage an ongoing process of self-evolution and self-responsibility, they can build true strength that makes them happy with themselves and displays their best qualities to others as well. The logic of using their capabilities to their fullest extent is undeniable to Architects, and when they set their sights on personal growth and choose to act, their limitations may be fewer than they thought.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Architect Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Architect Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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